RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

The Other Kinds of Reward: Blessings & Curses

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 3

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, continued: where this-worldly reward, Gan Eden and Gehinom fit

Shiur: Part 3 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 16 September 2025 (the week of Ki Tavo, before Rosh Hashanah)

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

1. **Five views** of the afterlife: **Gan Eden**, **Mashiach**, **techiyat hametim**, **this world**, **all combined**. All miss the real thing: **Olam HaBa**.
2. **Three readings of aggadah**: **literal**; **literal, so the Sages were wrong** (which angered the Rambam); and **metaphorical**, the true view, held by very few. Read the Sages physically, and you'll imagine a physical reward.
3. **Olam HaBa**: **עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך**. Wholly spiritual, so **a physical body can't comprehend it**: the **fish and heat**, the **blind man and colours**. The Sages used graphic images so the wise could draw out **something** of the truth.

A correction, mid-sentence. "And that's what our focus is on… **let me rephrase.** The Rambam wouldn't be happy if I said that." **We don't serve Hashem *for* Olam HaBa.** We are **עושי האמת מפני שהוא אמת**: we keep the mitzvot because they're **best for our character, identity, consciousness and intellect**. **Olam HaBa is what results.**

Olam HaBa = spiritual identity, **cleaving to Hashem**: grasping Godliness. The more refined your intellect and character, the closer the connection and the greater the bliss.

The Queen. "If **Queen Elizabeth**, *zichronah*, announced she'd spend time with people according to how refined and 'royal' they'd become, the more you'd learned royal etiquette and refined yourself, **the closer you'd get**. Swap in whoever you'd most love to meet. **That's Olam HaBa.**"

Tonight: where the other "rewards," with sources in Torah and Chazal, fit around it.

Part 1: Reward and Punishment in This World

The Torah's blessings and curses (**"didn't we just read them on Shabbat?"**):

> **היעודים הטובים והנקמות הרעות הכתובות בתורה, ענינם... כי הוא אומר לך: אם תעשה המצות האלה, אסייע לך על עשייתם והשלמות בהם, ואסיר מעליך המעיקים והמונעים כלם.**

If you keep these mitzvot, I'll help you keep them and perfect yourself in them, and remove every obstacle.

לפי שהאדם אי אפשר לו לעשות המצות כשהוא חולה ורעב וצמא, ולא בשעת מלחמה. No one can keep mitzvot while ill, hungry, thirsty or at war. So the Torah promises those will go, **so that they can complete**

.their knowledge and merit Olam HaBa

Maslow's hierarchy. "You can't think about culture or friendships before food and shelter. **You can't think about Olam HaBa, about who you want to be, while you're fighting to put bread on the table** or going from one illness to the next."

And the curses: abandon the Torah, and **those very conditions are withheld**, until you **can't** keep the mitzvot.

A new reading of Ki Tavo

תחת אשר לא עבדת את ה׳ אלהיך בשמחה ובטוב לבב מרב כל (Devarim 28:47)

Bang in the middle of the curses. The Rishonim ask: is the punishment for **not serving**, or for **not serving joyfully**?

	Reading
The common reading	You served, but **without joy**, so you were punished
The Rambam's	You **didn't serve** Hashem **when you had joy, a settled heart and plenty**: no illness, no money worries, **every ability to serve**. Not serving while fighting to survive is one thing; **with everything and still not serving**, Hashem says: *the conditions I gave you don't help you, so I'll take them away*

אם עשית קצת מצות מאהבה והשתדלות, אעזרך לעשות כולם... ואם תעזוב דבר מהם דרך בזיון, אביא לך מונעים שימנעוך מעשותם כולם.

"The reward of a mitzvah is a mitzvah"

שכר מצוה מצוה ושכר עבירה עבירה (Avot 4:2)

For the Rambam, who holds **mitzvot aren't done for reward**, this is the simplest reading: **the reward of a mitzvah is the ability to do more** (Hashem grants livelihood, health, peace of mind); **the consequence of a sin** is losing that ability: **under-development**.

"**Isn't this beautiful?** According to the Rambam there's **no reward and punishment written in the Torah at all.**"

- **Rabbi Akiva: שכר מצוה בהאי עלמא ליכא**: no reward in this world. "Seemingly preposterous, when the Torah says *do this, get that* over and over. **The Rambam: correct, because those aren't rewards.**"

  בדרך שאדם רוצה לילך מוליכין אותו: Hashem leads you down the path you choose.

  כל המקיים את התורה מעוני, סופו לקיימה מעושר; וכל המבטל את התורה מעושר, סופו לבטלה מעוני (Avot 4:9). *Wealth* in every sense: money, health, peace of mind.
- **Why doesn't the Torah mention Olam HaBa?** (Every Rishon asks; Monday night's topic.) **Because the Torah doesn't talk about reward at all.**

"Don't lose your life"

Rabbi Levi Yitzchak of Berditchev saw a man run out of shul mid-prayer: *I have to get to work, to make a living.* ***While you're running to make a living, be careful you don't lose your life.*** "We're so busy with day-to-day things that we can't think about **our mission in life**. **This season forces us to.**"

The paradox of progress. "We used to wash clothes **in the sea**; now we throw them in a **washing machine**. We should have so much more time to develop ourselves. **But more time means more**

distractions. Without that free time there'd be **no Hollywood**. The question is what we do with it. **Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur force us to ask.**"

A question: doesn't this make *tzaddik vera lo* worse?

If good deeds lead Hashem to remove obstacles, why do the righteous struggle?

"**I hear the question, and I've never thought of it that way. You're right: the Rambam's approach does make it bigger**, because you can't push it into some future calculation. Theodicy is **the biggest question** we've always had."

- **We never really know** what's going on in another person.
- **The Rambam himself** wrote in a letter that he suffered **depression for a couple of years** after his **brother** died.
- **Rav Chaim Vital** (the Arizal's transcriber, the source of most Kabbalah we have) wrote that for **two formative years** (around 23 to 25) **he couldn't learn**, and **wanted to study chemistry** instead.

  אין צדיק בארץ אשר לא יחטא; **וסביביו נשערה מאד**: Hashem may be stricter with those close to Him.

"Perhaps it's relative: it would have been harder." "**That's always the way out, I suppose.**"

Part 2: Gan Eden

A show of hands: *Gan Eden is after death? Or in this world?*

"As a kid I always thought it was some beautiful place **in heaven, after we die**. Some Rishonim say so. **The Rambam doesn't.** He holds Gan Eden is **a physical place on this earth.**"

> **וגן עדן הוא מקום דשן, מבחר הארץ, ורבים בו הנהרות והאילנות העושים פירות, יגלה אותו השם לבני אדם לעתיד לבוא, ויורה אותם הדרך ללכת בו, ויתענגו בו. ואפשר שימצאו בו צמחים נפלאים מאד, גדולי התועלת, ערבים מאד, מלבד הידועים אצלנו. וכל זה אינו נמנע ולא רחוק, אבל קרוב להיות.**

A fertile place, the choicest on earth, full of rivers and fruit trees, **which Hashem will reveal in the future** and show us **the way to it**. Perhaps it holds **wondrous plants**, beneficial and sweet, beyond those we know. **Not impossible or far-fetched**, all the more so since it's written in the Torah.

- **"In the future"** = Mashiach's days or the resurrection; **not revealed now**.
- **"Show us the way"**: because **Adam was expelled**: **ויגרש את האדם, וישכן מקדם לגן עדן את הכרבים ואת להט החרב המתהפכת לשמר את דרך עץ החיים**. "**It seems a physical place**, guarded by an ever-turning flaming sword. **That's the simple reading**, and the Rambam's."

"But Google Maps…"

"I think we've mapped **every metre** of the planet." *(Don: a quick search says 97–99%.) Caves; the ocean is less mapped than outer space.* "It is **slightly problematic**, I'll be honest."

- **The Ramban** (*Sha'ar HaGemul*): also physical, **below the equator**. He'd **heard reports from India** of sightings of **the ever-turning flame**.
- *"It's in Iran!"* "Where in Iran?" *"I read it. Persian people told me."* "**Let's go and see it.**" *"After we conquer Iran?"* "Maybe **that's** why we don't know yet."
- **The Ben Ish Chai's difficulty:** the Gemara says **the world is 1/60 of the Garden**, the Garden 1/60 of Eden. So if Gan Eden is on earth, it must be vast **but take up no space**, like **the Ark and Keruvim** that **took up no room** in the Holy of Holies. "I don't think **the Rambam** would accept that; he doesn't like impossibilities."

The key point: it's **very physical**: beautiful waters, drinks, **"wine pouring out."** So group 1 isn't **wrong**, **but it isn't the ultimate. It's one stage.**

Part 3: Gehinom

Three or four lines, against pages on Mashiach and resurrection.

ואמנם גיהנם הוא שם לצער ולעונש שישיג לרשעים, ולא פרשו בתלמוד תואר זה העונש.

A name for the pain and punishment of the wicked. The Talmud never described its nature.

Some say	Proof
The sun will draw near and burn them	**הנה היום בא בער כתנור** (Malachi)
A strange heat will arise in their bodies and burn them	**רוחכם אש תאכלכם**

External heat or internal heat. That's it.

The Shelah points out: in the **entire Mishneh Torah** there is **no real mention of Gehinom**, only in passing, quoting a Gemara that a careless **judge** may go there. **Gan Eden** appears only indirectly, in the **Sheva Berachot**: **שמח תשמח... כשמחך יצירך בגן עדן מקדם**.

They are not principles of faith. Deny **resurrection, Mashiach or eternity**, and you're a heretic. Deny **Gan Eden or Gehinom**: you contradict the Sages, **but it's minor in the grand scheme. This is crucial.**

The Ramban's reading of the Rambam

Some accused the Rambam, so brief on Gehinom, of **not believing in it**. **The Ramban: not true.** "I think his reading is correct."

First, recall: the ultimate punishment for the Rambam is **karet**, **the soul ceases to exist**. *(Class: "to go to hell?" "No." "Karet." "Good.")*

The Ramban's questions:

1. **Justice.** One man kept the whole Torah but **once**, knowingly, **ate on Yom Kippur** and never repented; another ate **every** Yom Kippur. **Both: karet.** Fair?
2. **The Mishnah's list.** Many sins carry **karet**: so what's special about **the heretic**, singled out as having **no portion**? *(This one can be answered: there are levels of karet.)*

His answer, in the Rambam's name: before karet comes **a process**: **Gehinom**, **up to twelve months**, **proportionate** to the severity. **The worst** (a *kofer*) gets karet **and** intense Gehinom.

Kaddish. "That's why people say Kaddish **twelve months**: the Gemara says Gehinom lasts at most twelve. People make **a massive thing** of it, every prayer. **In the grand scheme, it's not a major thing.**"

So:

	Nature	Duration	Principle of faith?
Gan Eden	**Physical pleasure**	**Temporary**	**No**
Gehinom	**Physical burning**, proportionate to the sin	**Temporary**	**No**
Olam HaBa	**The soul's eternal intellectual bliss**	**Forever**	**Yes**
Karet	**The soul ceases**	**Final**	

Other Rishonim: "waiting rooms"

	The Rambam	The Ramban, Ramchal and others
Olam HaBa	**Soul only**: pure intellect, consciousness	**Body and soul together**, in a future, renewed world
When	**The moment you die**: "the world *after* this one"	**In the future**
Gan Eden / Gehinom	**Physical places on earth**, in the future	**Spiritual waiting rooms** where souls are refined (after 120 years in the body) until that world comes
Why the difference	No gap to fill: **so they can't be waiting rooms**	

Open questions

Who enjoys the Rambam's Gan Eden: the body or the soul? The body's in the grave!

"**Excellent question.**" A participant: *maybe they're spiritual places in this world, invisible now, physical later.* "**Like the Ben Ish Chai.** But for the Rambam it's **physical**: one day we'll sit, eat and drink there."

So how do the dead wicked receive a physical Gehinom? The Rambam says resurrection is only for the righteous. Will the wicked be revived to be punished?

"**I don't think the Rambam believes that.** I need to think about it and check. **I don't have an answer now.**"

Summary

1. **Olam HaBa is the core**, but it's the **result** of doing truth, not the motive.
2. **This-worldly blessings and curses** aren't reward or punishment: **Hashem removes, or imposes, the obstacles** to serving Him. **Ki Tavo:** you didn't serve **when you had everything**. **שכר מצוה מצוה.** So **the Torah promises no reward at all.** (It does sharpen *tzaddik vera lo*.)
3. **Gan Eden is a physical place on earth**, to be revealed in the future. Real, but **one stage**, not the ultimate.
4. **Gehinom**: **a name for punishment**, some burning, undefined. Per the Ramban's reading, a **temporary**, proportionate stage **before karet**.
5. **Neither is a principle of faith**; the Mishneh Torah hardly mentions them. **Resurrection and Mashiach are**.

6. Other Rishonim: Gan Eden and Gehinom are **spiritual waiting rooms** before a body-and-soul Olam HaBa. **The Rambam's Olam HaBa begins at death.**

Coming Up

Techiyat hametim, "a foundation of Moshe Rabbeinu's Torah," and **Mashiach** at length; then: **"the ultimate is Olam HaBa,"** and **the 13 Principles**.

The schedule: Rosh Hashanah next Tuesday, then Erev Yom Kippur, Sukkot and Simchat Torah, so **probably no Tuesday night shiur until the week after Simchat Torah** (perhaps a Tuesday-morning one; watch the group).

A blessing: "May we have **all the blessings promised** (happiness, livelihood, health) **so that, with *simchah, rov kol and tuv levav***, we can come to Hashem, **work on ourselves, and become the best versions of ourselves.**"

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